

THE CARDINAL'S PROMISE

A Memoir of the Father Who Stayed

ROB BRIZZI

CARDINAL PROMISE PRESS

COPYRIGHT

THE CARDINAL'S PROMISE. Copyright © 2026 by Rob Brizzi.
All rights reserved.

No part of this book may be reproduced in any form or by any electronic or mechanical means, including information storage and retrieval systems, without written permission from the publisher, except by a reviewer, who may quote brief passages in a review.

Published by Cardinal Promise Press, Raleigh, North Carolina.

First edition, 2026.

Paperback ISBN: 979-8-9966446-0-5

Ebook ISBN: 979-8-9966446-1-2

This is a work of memoir. It reflects the author's present recollections of experiences over time. Some names and identifying details have been changed, some dialogue has been reconstructed, and some events are rendered as composites, as described in the Author's Note.

Cover design: Grace Nobrega

Printed in the United States of America.

For anyone who has struggled with addiction or loved someone who has

In memory of Lou Brizzi

1941–2025

For Hope, who tilted her head and said “We?”

CONTENTS

Foreword

Prologue

Part One — The Escape

1. Mexico City — The Escape
2. New Jersey: Survival
3. The Man Who Didn’t Have To
4. Chosen
5. The Man Who Raised Me

Part Two — The Mat

6. The Wrestler
7. What the Mat Left
8. The Suit
9. When I Worked for the Mob
10. Oxford
11. MTV

Part Three — The Fall

12. My Brother’s Keeper
13. The Performance Trap
14. Checking Boxes
15. West Palm Beach
16. New Orleans

Part Four — Getting Square

17. Chumuckla
18. The Quiet Years
19. The People You Meet When You Stop Drinking

- 20. Horacio
- 21. The Line
- 22. The Salmon Palace
- 23. They Gave Me a Chance
- 24. Making Amends

Part Five — Hope

- 25. Hope
- 26. What We Built
- 27. Sobriety Meets Hospice

Part Six — The Last Chapter

- 28. The Detour
- 29. Five Weeks
- 30. The Days After
- 31. The First Honest Mile
- 32. What Grief Taught the Job
- 33. The Table

Epilogue: The Cardinal's Promise

A Note to the One Who Loves an Addict

Tyler and Jaye

The Empty Chair

What I'm Asking You to Do

Lou's Way

Afterword

Author's Note

Acknowledgments

A Reader's Guide

Resources

About the Author

FOREWORD

There is a kind of wisdom that can only be earned by living through what most people spend their lives trying to avoid. Not in a classroom. Not through credentials. But through competition and failure, addiction and recovery, grief and responsibility, and the long hours spent beside people in the final chapter of their lives. Rob Brizzi has that kind of wisdom, and this book is the evidence of it.

I have known Rob for thirty-five years, and a friendship like that gives you a long view of a man's life. Over those years we bonded over faith, character, and a shared belief in showing up and doing right by people. I knew him long before this book, long before the wisdom in these pages had taken shape, long enough to remember the younger version of him, full of energy and loyalty, the guy who hauled a buddy's Jeep doors around Long Beach Island in ninety-five-degree heat, no shade, just because somebody needed help moving. That was Rob being Rob. He has a servant's heart, and he has had it from the beginning. What I did not know back then was everything going on underneath: the battles he was fighting, the identity he was trying to find, the long road that would bring him here, to the writing of this book.

FOREWORD

Rob was a serious competitor. As a wrestler in high school and college he learned something most people never do, that at the highest levels the physical is only the beginning, and the real contest is internal. He learned that hard work separates the people who merely want something from the people willing to pay the price for it. Formation like that does not leave a man. It shapes the way he meets every challenge that comes after.

And the challenges kept coming. Rob spent years in business, where his success came from his authenticity and his ability to become an expert in whatever he was doing. He learned to listen for what people need beneath what they say they want. Those skills are foundational to this book.

The credential that mattered most is the one that cost him the most to earn. Rob walked through the valley himself. He battled addiction. He knows what it is to be lost, to reach for something that promises relief and gives you nothing back, to hit the bottom that forces a man to look honestly at who he is. He came through that fire transformed. He stopped trying to build his worth on performance, and what he found on the other side was steadier, a deeper sense of who he was and what mattered. It is something he has lived.

Dave Meyer

PROLOGUE

“He brought me up also out of an horrible pit, out of the miry clay, and set my feet upon a rock, and established my goings.” — Psalm 40:2

Tijuana, Mexico, 2005

His hands were around my throat before I understood he had crossed the cell. A small man, wired, moving too fast, meth or something close to it, his eyes too wide and his whole body ready to fly apart. Somebody called him Rico. His face came an inch from mine, and the only English he had came out in a rasp. “Gringo. Gringo. Money.”

“No tengo dinero,” I told him. The words came out thin. It was true. They had already taken everything.

“Money. Money.” The fingers pressed, eased, pressed again. His breath was sour and chemical. Then the hands dropped. He muttered something, backed to the wall, and the dark took him.

The night had started ordinary. A workday, a Tuesday in my San Diego years, and when I was done I crossed into Tijuana. I’d crossed enough times to think I understood how it worked, and that was the

problem. Do something dangerous often enough and it starts to feel like a run.

This time a cop saw the watch.

He took it first. Then the bag. Then everything else in my pockets. For a moment I thought that might be the end of it, that I'd be sent back across the line with one more story I'd never tell. Then he pulled me out of the car.

It wasn't a prison. It was a holding cell in a building I couldn't have found again the next day. I didn't know where I was, who knew I was there, or how long they meant to keep me.

The smell reached me before the door shut. Sewer and vomit and mold, sweat over the top of it, something rotten underneath. When it closed, the dark seemed to move. I stood still and waited for my eyes to adjust. They didn't, not really. Shapes shifted. Breathing came from every direction. In the corner a wet cough ran too long and ended in a rattle. A rat crossed the floor after a cockroach, claws on concrete, the pounce, a soft crunch, and was gone.

The men spoke Spanish faster than I could follow. It had been my first language once. Mexico was where I started. By now it was buried far enough down that I could hear it without holding it, and the words moved past me in pieces.

Some of the men were gone in the head, rocking, laughing, talking to no one. Others sat with their backs to the wall and their eyes empty. A few just watched me. I didn't belong there, and they knew it. Rico was one of them.

My throat burned. I wanted to put a hand to it and didn't. I wasn't going to let the room see it. I slid down the wall instead and sat, knees to my chest, the concrete cold through my clothes, my forehead down. I knew the position. My body found it before my mind caught up. Get small, stay quiet, don't hold anyone's eye, don't give the room a reason to pick you. It was the same shape I'd folded into as a boy when the yelling started.

PROLOGUE

There was no bedroom this time. No hallway light, no mother down the hall. No father in the stands. And no one on earth knew where I was.

Not my father. Not my brother. Not my mother. No one.

I sat on a concrete floor in Mexico with my head on my knees, and the life I'd been performing, the sales job, the income, the watch, the lines I used to sound like more, was somewhere else. What was left was the smell, the dark, and my own breathing.

I lost track of time. The voices flattened into noise. I thought about my mother, her hand around mine in the airport when I was four, the woman who carried me out of this country to give me a life. I'd come back to take myself apart. Then my father, Lou. That was worse. He'd chosen me, made me his son, sat in the bleachers and paid the bills and handed over money he didn't have, and never once made me feel I had to earn the place. And I'd put myself here.

I wanted to pray and couldn't. I still believed, somewhere under it. I couldn't ask for help out of a hole I'd dug myself.

The door opened. Light cut in. I looked up and stayed where I was, afraid it was for someone else, afraid to stand too fast. A man said something and waved me forward. I got up. My legs were wrong under me. I stepped around the wet places and around the men, past Rico, who didn't look at me. Outside the air wasn't clean, but it was air. Someone gave me back enough to walk out with. Not all of it. Enough.

I went back the next day.

It wasn't the moment I changed. I was scared, and fear isn't surrender; fear wears off. There was more running ahead of me, more lying, more damage. I'd seen how small my life had gotten. A cell, a rat, a man's hands on my throat, a concrete floor, and me folded against the wall hoping no one noticed me.

PROLOGUE

I never told anyone. Not my father, my brother, my mother, my wife. Not a sponsor, not a priest. I carried it out of shame, and the longer I kept it hidden, the harder it got to say.

I had been carried out of Mexico City as a child, to be given a better life. Twenty-three years later I had found my way back to a concrete floor inside the same country. This is the story of how I came back from that floor, and why my father never stopped coming for me.

THE ESCAPE

PART ONE

THE ESCAPE

Before I chose anything else, I chose a father.

CHAPTER 1

Mexico City — The Escape

“The LORD shall preserve thy going out and thy coming in from this time forth, and even for evermore.” — Psalm 121:8

Mexico City, 1982

“Claudio,” my mother said, “you will love this story.”

That summer she was obsessed with *E.T.* The movie wasn’t even out yet, but she’d already tracked down and read the paperback. One afternoon she sat me down to explain it. She told me about an alien left behind by his spaceship, and the boy who hid him in his room to try to get him home.

“What are aliens?” I asked.

She stopped and thought for a second.

“People,” she said. “Just from somewhere so far away you can’t even imagine it.”

I tried to. I couldn’t.

The only world I knew was Mexico City. I was four years old.

We lived in Bosques de Aragón, in a two-story brick row house on a dead-end street, the houses wrapped around a patch of grass. The walls were thick and you heard everything anyway. Radios. Fights. The street vendors shouting before sunrise. Music from

passing cars and open windows. Overhead, old sneakers hung by their laces from the power lines, swinging in the breeze.

Rosa María and Armando lived next door. A clothesline ran between our balconies, always full of sheets drying stiff under the hot sun. Every morning started the same way: my mother put a pot of beans on the stove, and the whole house filled with the smell. Beans, onions, sugar, and the warm bread she bought from the bakery on the corner.

My mother taught English at a little preschool called Cascabelito. Little Bell. Because she worked there, I got to go for free. In the afternoons she'd put on music and dance around the kitchen while making tacos. She would scoop my little brother, Chris, up on her hip and sing along to "The Locomotion," and I'd dance right next to her because she was happy. That was all the reason I needed.

Her name was Becky. She was twenty-seven, the oldest of Bob and Jan Pontier's three girls, and a long way from Cedar Grove, New Jersey. She had followed a man to the middle of Mexico City for love, and built a new life there. I didn't understand that kind of love back then.

I didn't understand the sacrifice. I knew the smell of dinner, the music playing in the kitchen, and her hand reaching down to hold mine.

The man was my papa, Horacio. She had met him in Acapulco around 1974, on a trip with Sue Doyle, her best friend from high school. He was in college then, working twenty-four-hour shifts at a hospital, and he'd call her when he got off. She went home. Years later she came back to Mexico with my aunt Nancey, asked around until she found him, and caught him the day before he left to guide tours in Greece. She moved to Mexico on the spot. Part of it was him. Part of it was getting away from her father. She learned Spanish from the soap operas.

My mother's father, the man I'd grow up calling Grandpa Bob, didn't approve of the marriage. Papa's father was the one who insisted on it. My parents had already married in Mexico, and in 1977 they did it again in Cedar Grove, New Jersey, with mariachis. My grandfather came around to Papa over the years, but he never got over how far away she lived.

My mother makes her own way. She always has. She loved my father. Chris and I came from that.

My papa was a proud man. He worked a government job, and every morning he left the house in pressed clothes. Mostly he took me to the park and the movies. He'd take off running and I'd come after him and we'd race. He always got there first. Then he'd turn around with a grin and say, "Wow, you're fast today." And I'd yell, "I'm fast!" I believed him every time.

He bought me my own record player, a Fisher-Price like the neighbor's. One day he came home excited about a promotion and picked me up. Claudio, you are my good luck charm. That was my name then. Claudio Horacio Balderas — his own name folded into the middle of mine. When my father looked at you, you were the center of the world. He told me he was proud of me and I ran around the house like I owned it.

At night he told me a story, his voice low, like every word mattered. The rabbit in the moon. He said a long time ago a god came down and walked the earth as a tired old man, hungry, and the only one who shared what little he had was a small rabbit. To thank him, the god lifted the rabbit up and pressed his shape into the moon, so anyone who looked up would remember. Look, he'd say. He's still up there. I'd ask him to tell it again. Just the two of us in the dark, and I never wanted it to end.

But there was another side to Papa. He'd sit in cafés after work, playing chess, drinking coffee, not coming home. Some weekends he slept straight through, and his own father had to come and wake him.

One Thanksgiving my mom cooked the whole dinner, and Papa never got up for it. Other times he left for work and didn't come back. A day. Then two. Then three. Then he'd walk in worn out, his eyes gone somewhere, go straight to the bedroom, lock the door, and shut the house out.

I'd push the door open a crack and look in. He was always asleep. The air in that room was different from the rest of the house. I couldn't have told you how. A kid just knows it. Sometimes I heard him crying through the door.

Then he'd come out and act as if nothing had happened. We'd have dinner. He'd read to me until I fell asleep.

You never knew which Papa you were going to get. It took me years to understand I'd been watching two different men.

When my mother pushed back, it turned. One night it went physical, a single slap, and that one time told her what the locked doors and the disappearances had only hinted at. His family knew, and they took his side. She had told them more than once that she was going to leave. They told her that if she did, they would keep one of us. The threat to take a child was the thing she could not live with. In the end, that's why we left.

There's a picture of me from back then. A little kid in a Mickey Mouse shirt washed so many times it had gone gray, though Mickey still held his color. I wore it until it fell apart.

After my mom, I loved Ricardo, my older cousin. A few years ahead of me, which at that age is a whole generation, and I followed him everywhere. One day he took me to the market for gum. He walked me down the rows, naming things, while I looked at all of it. The gum came in big wrappers in every color, and there was one flavor every kid in the neighborhood wanted. We found it. I walked home with a piece of it in my cheek.

My mom got pregnant with Chris when I was two; he was born just before I turned three. The week before, I wouldn't let my mother

put me down. I'd grab her hips while she walked and let her drag me along the floor. "Let me down," she kept saying. I didn't want down. I wanted to be carried. She told me she couldn't carry me anymore because there was going to be another baby. I asked if the baby could be mine. She said yes.

When she came through the door with him I climbed up on the couch next to her. "Is that my baby? Can I hold him?" She put him in my arms. He let out a thin little cry and I didn't know what to do with it. "Okay," I said. "I'll try again later." And I handed him back.

For years I told Chris he'd been small enough to fit in my pocket when he was born. He believed me. That was the fun part of having a little brother. He believed everything you said.

Chris was a crybaby. His ears, my mother said. She'd hold him for hours. I'd go to my room and play the same record again. But I got used to it. He was mine, after all. I'd asked, and she'd said yes.

After several years of marriage my mother had seen enough. Love was never the question. She didn't announce anything. She got our passports quietly and said we were going to New Jersey to visit Grandpa. Two weeks. Like every other trip. I believed her completely.

Papa stood in the hallway with a folded newspaper under his arm. "I'll see you in two weeks," he said. He believed it too. My mother kissed him. "I love you," she said. I hugged him goodbye. I think I had the Mickey Mouse shirt on.

Chris was about a year and a half when we left Mexico. Hazel eyes, light skin. Not like me.

Then the airport. My mother carried a suitcase and Chris while I dragged a little red one behind me. I'd flown once before, as a baby, to Houston, but a baby keeps nothing. As far as I knew, I'd never seen a plane up close. The engines came up through the floor and the seat and into me. When we started down the runway something pushed me back into my seat. I looked out the window. The houses

and the streets slid by, slow and then fast, until they ran together and dropped away under the clouds.

The only world I'd ever known was gone. I didn't know that's what I was watching. I thought I'd see it again in two weeks.

My mom showed me how to pop my ears. I blew too hard and it scared me. Then I put my head on her arm and fell asleep.

She sat awake. The whole flight she was waiting for someone to stop her, at the gate, in the aisle, at the door. She held her breath, ready to be pulled off the plane before it took off. She was leaving the country where she'd tried to build a life with a man she loved and couldn't live with. The market where Ricardo bought my first piece of gum. The school with the little bell. The cul-de-sac, the grass, the thick walls, Rosa María and Armando next door. She was walking away from all of it on purpose, and she couldn't grieve any of it yet. I was asleep on her arm.

We landed in New Jersey at the start of winter. The airport felt like home at first. Same crowds, same noise, everyone rushing. Then I started listening. The words were wrong. Not Spanish. Something else. Everybody around me knew something I didn't.

My aunt Nancey picked us up in her small red Honda Civic and drove us to my grandparents' place in West Paterson. I stepped outside and saw my own breath for the first time. I didn't know that could even happen. I'd only seen smoke like that come off a cigarette.

My Spanish disappeared almost overnight. English was everywhere and I picked it up the way kids do, without deciding to. Back home I'd had a lisp. In New Jersey they sent me to speech therapy twice a week to fix the way I talked. Decades later it still comes out at the worst times.

My mom had called Papa when we landed and told him the truth. We weren't coming back. About six months later he came anyway. He tried to make a life here, got a job at a Mexican restaurant called

El Torito, where they hired him because he was Mexican. For a while he was around. Chris wasn't even two and couldn't say the name. He called it el durito and talked about the balloons. But the old patterns were still there, the same bars, the same nights he didn't come home, and he couldn't make it work. He went back to Mexico. It would be years before I saw him again.

My grandfather was strict, and he'd never approved of the marriage. But he let us in. We paid him eight hundred a month. He was hard on her and soft on us, and my grandmother took on most of the days. I missed my father. My mom started over with no degree and nobody to fall back on, and she worked. That's her story to tell, in her own voice, and I hope she does. This book is here because of her. She picked us.

In that airport, her hand had closed around mine. That was all I had. Her hand, and what she'd told me, and my belief that we'd be back soon. I was wrong about soon. But Mexico wasn't done with me.

CHAPTER 2

New Jersey: Survival

“Strength and honour are her clothing; and she shall rejoice in time to come.” — Proverbs 31:25

West Paterson, New Jersey, 1983

Two weeks became the rest of my life.

The first thing New Jersey took from me was the noise. In Mexico City, sound had been the texture of every day. My grandparents’ house in West Paterson had none of it. The quiet there was on purpose, and the house ran on a schedule: dinner at the same time, lights out at the same time, conversation that never wandered past what could be handled politely. It wasn’t unkind, only contained. After where I’d come from, contained felt close to safe.

Before long I had friends on the street, Frank and Jason, and I’d run to find them and be outside all day. English came fast because there was no other way, and my Spanish went quiet faster than anyone expected, a word here, a phrase there, then one day I caught myself translating in my head, and not long after I’d stopped translating. School confused me. I understood more than I could say, so I watched the other kids for cues, when to talk, when to laugh, how to stand, and learned it was safer to take a room in than to announce myself. My name was Claudio Horacio Balderas, and in a

class of John Smiths and Erik Thomases nobody could say any of it, so they landed on Cloudio and that stuck.

If a grown-up had asked me back then what I wanted to be when I grew up, I wouldn't have had a job to name. The honest answer was one word. Survive. Get through the day, stay small, don't give anyone a reason to look twice.

My mother worked all the time, jobs nobody hands a title to. She left early and came home tired, and I saw far less of her than I had in Mexico. At night I'd climb into her bed and ask to play with her hair, and some nights she let me. The nights she did, something settled in my chest I couldn't have named. She kept food on the table, kept us clean, kept us safe. The thing I hold onto most isn't the big sacrifices, and there were plenty. It's smaller than that. She waitressed long nights, on her feet for hours, the kind of tired that sinks into your back and stays. On her way home she would call to see if I was still up.

The phone would ring once, maybe twice, and I'd grab it before it woke the house. I could hear the car around her, the engine, the road.

"You still up?"

"Yeah."

"You want McDonald's?"

I always said yes, and she always knew the order before I gave it. Two double cheeseburgers, no mustard, no onion, fries, and a vanilla shake. She'd brought it home a hundred times. Then the car door, the bag crinkling, the smell of it before I even saw her, and her face, worn all the way down, watching me eat. A woman who had spent the whole night feeding strangers, coming home to feed her kid one more time before she slept. People ask me how I knew my mother loved me. That's how.

And it never stopped after I grew up. I moved more times than I can count, and every time, she made the new place a home. She

would go to T.J. Maxx and fill a cart, and a bare apartment I had just landed in would turn into somewhere that felt like mine. In college she even bought me a Jenny McCarthy poster and hung it on my wall, because making a place mine meant making it feel like me, right down to the parts a mother would rather not picture. I felt loved. The vanilla shake at midnight. The lamp from T.J. Maxx, picked out so I wouldn't have to walk into an empty room.

Years later, coming back from a cruise through Mexico, tanned so deep I looked, in the official eyes of United States customs, very Mexican, I got pulled aside. The paper looked unofficial, they said. Security questioned me for an hour, then the police arrived, then, two hours after that, the FBI. Seven hours off the boat, fourteen different officers, the same answers every time. I wasn't nervous. For once I had nothing to hide. I was just embarrassed, all the way through, and somewhere around hour five I caught myself wondering whether this was going to be the rest of my life, proving on demand that I was who the paper said I was. My mother heard about it and did what she does. She went to a New Jersey courthouse and came home with an official birth certificate, so nobody could ever again hold her son for seven hours over the way a document looked.

Chris took to New Jersey without trouble. He'd been a year and a half when we left Mexico. I'd been four.

At night I thought about Horacio, not with anger, with confusion, half-expecting him to turn up one day so we could pick things back up. I didn't know how to love a man who was gone but not dead. No funeral, no grave, no explanation a child could hold. The grown-ups rarely spoke of him, and when they did it was careful, the way you handle something that might break if you name it straight.

My grandparents gave me what they had, which was steadiness, a house that stayed where it was, meals that came when they were supposed to. Not the warmth my mother gave, but reliable, and that counts for a lot when the ground has just moved.

My grandfather was a high school history teacher. At home he was a simple man, and I loved him for it. He was devoted to Wendy's, the Frosties most of all, and told me once, dead serious, that the one hole in his life was that Wendy's wouldn't sell hot dogs. He and my nana drank port wine every night out of paper cups, from a jug they kept. He swore by Ivory soap for every part of a man, no shampoo needed, and said it like classified information. He put ketchup on everything — ketchup on the ketchup — a habit I took whole. He took me to the railroad tracks once and showed me how to lay a quarter on the rail, run off, and come back after the train to find it flattened smooth. My mother didn't agree when she found out, and he never saw the problem. We played UNO and war and checkers, and Chris took up chess with him, but chess was never mine, and UNO was enough.

My grandfather had a hard childhood, harder than he ever let on. His own father was an alcoholic who died passed out on a railroad track, hit by a train. My grandfather and his brother Jack joined the army at sixteen, lying about their age, and sent their pay home to their mother. He met my grandmother at Hope Church in Michigan, where she played the organ, when they were both in college. For a man who taught for a living, he never pushed my mother or her sisters, Terry and Nancey, toward college. The way they tell it, he'd say they were all pretty and would find good husbands. That just wasn't the expectation in their house.

Then there was my nana, Jan, who could catch you off guard with her gentleness. One afternoon, not long after I'd learned about cowboys and Indians in school, she mentioned she had some American Indian in her. I burst into tears and ran to my mother. There's an Indian, she's an Indian.

There's a story from those years. My mother always wore red nail polish, my aunt Nancey always pink. That was how the world was arranged. Then one day they came home with the colors

switched, and I lost it: sobbing, insisting they had it wrong and had to put it back. They went and changed their nails again just to settle me. It wasn't a tantrum, it was panic. I had lost a country, a father, and a language. The nail colors were one thing that stayed where it belonged, and then they didn't. The need to hold things in place never fully left me.

And there was Nancey, my mother's youngest sister, who treated Chris and me as her own from the start. She was at the games and the matches, always in our corner. Early twenties when we arrived from Mexico, years before she met Charlie. She told me not long ago that no matter how old I get she'll always see the same little kid, and I know the one she means: the boy in the backseat too scared to get out of the car.

And there was my aunt Terry, whose family had the house at Pines Lake. Terry was the one we had flown to see in Houston when her son, my cousin Kevin, was born, my mother pregnant with Chris, Nancey and my grandparents all crowding into the little two-bedroom with us. The American thread never broke, even from Mexico City. Once we landed in New Jersey for good, her house was where the ordinary kid memories got made. A Halloween with the three of us in costume on the kitchen floor, tearing into the candy, Kevin as He-Man, me as a pumpkin, and Wolfie, their German Shepherd, dressed as Battle Cat. Hide-and-seek on the metal railing between the levels, where I was sure I was hidden and laughed until I cried when I sprang out and scared the one who came looking. Kevin glued to his Nintendo while the rest of us ran. A pool where somebody towed me dry while I announced I was cold, and I jumped straight back in.

What I love now is how close my mother and her sisters have become, she and Nancey and Terry, a closeness that deepened after they lost their own mother. Watching my nana go was hard. The dementia took her in pieces, the person still in the room while the

line kept dropping. That slow disappearing stayed with me. Years later I earned my Certified Dementia Practitioner credential. I was thinking of her when I did. But that was decades ahead. Back then I still missed my father, and nobody talked about him. I didn't know a man was about to show up.

\newpage

The story continues...

The story continues...

The Cardinal's Promise is a memoir of addiction, adoption, immigration, and the father who stayed — from the wrestling mats of New Jersey to the hallways of hospice care.

Available in paperback and ebook.

Rob Brizzi · Cardinal Promise Press